

- RAG Learning

1.6 Liberalism

Politics — Edexcel (9PL0) — Component 1: Core Political Ideas, Section B

Liberalism is a **core** idea in Section B of Component 1, so every student sits it. It is the ideology that has shaped the modern Western state most directly — representative government, the rule of law, individual rights, the market economy are all liberal achievements — which makes it easy to describe and hard to evaluate, because its assumptions look like common sense. The marks are in the split between classical and modern liberalism.

Foundational equality — rights that all humans have by virtue of being born, which cannot be taken away (natural or inalienable rights).

Formal equality — all individuals have the same legal and political rights.

Equality of opportunity — all individuals should have equal chances in life to rise and fall.

Social contract — the state is set up with the agreement of the people, and exists to serve and protect them.

Meritocracy — a society organised so that success rests on ability and hard work.

Mechanistic theory — the state was created by human beings to serve their interests, not ordained or organically grown.

Tolerance — willingness to respect values, customs and beliefs with which one disagrees.

Limited government — government restrained by checks and balances and a separation of powers, because power corrupts.

Negative freedom — absence of external constraint and non-interference in the private sphere.

Positive freedom — personal fulfilment and the realisation of one's potential.

Egoistical individualism — freedom associated with self-interest and self-reliance.

Developmental individualism — freedom linked to human flourishing.

1. Core ideas and principles

Principle	What it means	Why liberals hold it
Individualism	The individual is the basic unit of moral and political value	Society exists for individuals, not the reverse; collective claims must be justified back to them
Freedom	The supreme political value	Individuals are rational and self-determining, so they should choose their own conception of the good
Rationalism	Humans can reason, and can order their own affairs	Grounds opposition to paternalism; without it, being governed by others would be justified
Equality	Foundational and formal equality; equality of opportunity	Follows from equal moral worth — but stops short of equality of outcome
Limited government	Constitutionalism, separation of powers, rule of law	Power corrupts, and those holding it are as self-interested as anyone else
Liberal democracy	Government by consent, with limits on what majorities may decide	Consent legitimises; entrenched rights protect against the tyranny of the majority

The liberal view of human nature

All liberals begin from **rationality**: human beings can reason, judge their own interests and direct their own lives. This single premise does a great deal of work — it grounds foundational equality, government by consent, toleration and the harm principle. If people were not rational, paternalism would be justified and the entire liberal architecture would collapse.

Where liberals differ is on what rationality *implies*. Classical liberals treat individuals as **egoistical** — self-interested, self-reliant, best left alone. Modern liberals treat them as **developmental** — capable of flourishing, but only where the social conditions for exercising reason exist. That is the disagreement from which all the others follow.

2. Classical and modern liberalism

	Classical liberalism	Modern liberalism
Freedom	Negative — absence of constraint	Positive — capacity for self-realisation
Individualism	Egoistical	Developmental
The state	Minimal — "night-watchman"; a necessary evil	Enabling — removes obstacles to freedom
Economy	Laissez-faire; free contract	Regulation, progressive taxation, Keynesian management
Equality	Formal and of opportunity, narrowly understood	Substantive opportunity, requiring social provision
Welfare	Breeds dependency; charity is preferable	Necessary to make rights meaningful
Thinkers	Locke, Wollstonecraft, (early) Mill	(later) Mill, Rawls, Friedan

Why modern liberals accepted a larger state

- **A changed conception of freedom.** If freedom is the capacity to realise one's potential, then poverty, ignorance and illness are obstacles to it just as legal restrictions are.
- **Formal rights may be empty.** A person with the legal right to take a job but no education to qualify for it is not meaningfully free. Removing the legal barrier is insufficient where the social obstacle remains.
- **Industrial conditions.** Concentrated economic power meant laissez-faire produced dependence rather than autonomy, so an unregulated market appeared as a threat to freedom rather than its expression.
- **Continuity of purpose.** Modern liberals argue this is an extension rather than an abandonment: the objective remains individual autonomy, and the state is a means to it.

The classical objection is real and not fully answered: taxation and provision are themselves coercion, so the enabling state restricts some individuals' negative freedom in order to enlarge others' positive freedom.

3. Key thinkers

John Locke (1632–1704) — *Two Treatises of Government* (1689). In the state of nature humans possess **natural rights** to life, liberty and property, and a natural law discoverable by reason. The state is created by a **social contract** to protect those rights, and its authority rests on the **consent** of the governed. Government is therefore limited by its purpose, and a government that violates the contract may legitimately be resisted. This is the **mechanistic theory** of the state — made by people, for people.

Mary Wollstonecraft (1759–97) — *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792). Women are **rational beings** and therefore entitled to the same natural rights, education and formal equality as men. Their apparent frivolity is the product of an education designed to produce it, not of nature. Her argument extends liberalism rather than departing from it: she applies the liberal premise of rationality to a group liberalism had excluded, which is why she belongs in a core liberalism answer rather than only in feminism.

John Stuart Mill (1806–73) — *On Liberty* (1859). The **harm principle**: "the only purpose for which power can be rightfully exercised over any member of a civilised community, against his will, is to prevent harm to others." Self-regarding actions are not a legitimate object of coercion. Mill also defends freedom of expression on the ground that suppressing an opinion robs humanity of the chance to exchange error for truth. He is the **bridge** between classical and modern liberalism: he defends negative freedom while treating liberty as the condition for individual *development*.

John Rawls (1921–2002) — *A Theory of Justice* (1971). Behind a **veil of ignorance**, not knowing your class, talents, gender or conception of the good, you would choose two principles: first, equal basic liberties for all, which has priority; second, the **difference principle**

— inequalities are permissible only where they work to the greatest benefit of the least advantaged, and attach to positions open to all under fair equality of opportunity. Risk aversion drives the reasoning: any of us might turn out to occupy the worst position.

Betty Friedan (1921–2006) — *The Feminine Mystique* (1963). Women were confined by **cultural expectation** rather than by law — "the problem that has no name" — so formal legal equality was insufficient. Liberation required access to education, work and public life. Her position is liberal feminism: reform of institutions and attitudes so that women can compete on equal terms, rather than transformation of the social order.

Exam Tip: Edexcel specifies five liberal thinkers: **Locke, Wollstonecraft, Mill, Rawls and Friedan**. T. H. Green is useful background for modern liberalism but is *not* a specified thinker (AQA names the same five). Learn all five, and use Mill as your bridge between the two strands — that relationship earns more than an extra name would.

4. Liberalism on the state, society, the economy and democracy

	Position	Internal disagreement
The state	Necessary to secure rights; created by consent; limited and constitutional	Minimal (Locke, Nozick-adjacent) against enabling (Rawls, Friedan)
Society	A collection of individuals pursuing their own conceptions of the good; toleration is essential	Whether society imposes obligations, or only individuals' voluntary undertakings do
The economy	Private property and the market as expressions of individual choice	Laissez-faire against regulated capitalism with redistribution
Democracy	Government by consent, constrained by rights	Enthusiasm against anxiety about the tyranny of the majority

Liberal ambivalence about democracy

Liberalism's relationship with democracy is more complicated than it appears. Mill and Tocqueville warned of the **tyranny of the majority**: a majority may oppress minorities and suppress dissent as effectively as any despot. Since liberalism's fundamental commitment is to individual liberty, majority rule is valuable only insofar as it protects that liberty.

Mill supported representative government but proposed *plural voting* weighted towards the educated — a position hard to reconcile with foundational equality. Early liberals often restricted the franchise to property owners. The resolution liberals reached is **liberal democracy**: majority rule constrained by entrenched rights, judicial review, constitutionalism and a separation of powers. The tension has not disappeared — placing some questions beyond majority decision is exactly the feature critics call undemocratic and liberals regard as essential.

Toleration

Liberal toleration does not rest on the claim that all beliefs are equally true. It rests on autonomy: individuals are rational and self-determining, so imposing belief violates the very capacity that makes them worth respecting. It also rests on Mill's epistemic argument — that truth emerges from the free contest of ideas, so suppression harms the suppressor as much as the suppressed.

5. Handling a "To what extent" question

- **"To what extent do liberals agree about freedom?"** — complete agreement that freedom is supreme; fundamental disagreement about what it is. Judgement: one commitment generates opposite conclusions about state power, which makes the disagreement internal rather than a split.
- **"To what extent do liberals agree about the role of the state?"** — agreement it is necessary, made by consent and limited; disagreement over whether limiting it means minimising it. Note that modern liberals must answer the charge that taxation is itself coercion.
- **"To what extent is liberalism consistent about human nature?"** — one shared premise (rationality), two incompatible accounts of the conditions under which it is realised. The second disagreement does most of the political work.
- **"To what extent do liberals support democracy?"** — they support *liberal* democracy, and the qualification is the answer. Mill's plural voting and the property franchise show the ambivalence is

historical, not invented by critics.

Exam Tip: The Nozick objection to Rawls is the highest-value single argument available here: redistribution to satisfy the difference principle treats some people's talents and earnings as a resource for others, violating self-ownership however justly those holdings were acquired. It works in a liberalism answer and in a conservatism answer, and it shows the examiner you can connect the two ideologies.

Quick recall

- Core: individualism, freedom, rationalism, equality (foundational/formal/opportunity), limited government, liberal democracy
- Negative freedom (classical) against positive freedom (modern) — the disagreement all others follow from
- Egoistical against developmental individualism
- Thinkers: Locke, Wollstonecraft, Mill, Rawls, Friedan — **five**; T. H. Green is useful background, not a specified thinker
- Locke: natural rights, social contract, consent, mechanistic state
- Mill: harm principle; the bridge between the two strands
- Rawls: veil of ignorance; liberty first, then the difference principle
- Liberals support liberal democracy — majority rule constrained by rights, because of the tyranny of the majority